

## JIRGA — TRADITIONAL GOVERNANCE

“An Assembly Where Community Questions Become Collective Questions”

Assembly Deliberation Consensus Conflict Resolution Community Order

For generations, Pashtun communities have used assemblies known as jirgas to discuss disputes, relationships, communal concerns and questions affecting collective life.

The jirga is difficult to translate into one modern institution. It can resemble a council; in some contexts, it performs functions associated with mediation; in others, it becomes a mechanism through which a tribe or community collectively responds to a major dispute or political challenge. But it is not simply a traditional version of a modern parliament or court. Its meaning comes from the social world in which it operates.<sup>1</sup>



“Jirga historically functioned through collective deliberation rather than through a modern bureaucratic hierarchy.”

SCHOLARLY DEFINITIONS: HANIFI, AHMED, AND BARTH

As anthropologist M. Jamil Hanifi documents in his authoritative *\*Encyclopaedia Iranica\** entry, the jirga is an assembly or council of local adult men sitting in a circular formation for the resolution of conflicts and discussion of issues and challenges. Importantly, Hanifi notes that historical claims characterizing the jirga as simply a judicial, legislative, and executive government agency are not fully supported by the historical record. Rather, it is invoked when needed rather than existing as a permanent bureaucratic institution.<sup>2</sup>

Similarly, scholars like Akbar S. Ahmed (*\*Pukhtun Economy and Society\**) and Fredrik Barth (*\*Political Leadership Among Swat Pathans\**) explore how leadership, consensus, and tribal governance operate in practice, distinguishing ordinary local assemblies from major confederation councils (*\*loya jirga\**) and smaller deliberative gatherings (*\*maraka\**).<sup>3</sup>

| MARAKA                                      | JIRGA                                     | LOYA JIRGA                                           |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Smaller-scale gathering<br>Local discussion | Community assembly<br>Dispute & mediation | Grand national council<br>Political / constitutional |

“Maraka, local jirga, and loya jirga represent distinct scales of customary deliberation.”

Visually and socially, the jirga is characterized by its circular seating arrangement. Historically, participants sat together in a circle, symbolizing collective participation rather than a single throne or presiding authority. This structural format encouraged open debate, argumentation, and consensus-building among community members and elders.<sup>4</sup>

### ASSEMBLY • DELIBERATION • CONSENSUS • RESPONSIBILITY

#### AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

For me, the most powerful image of the jirga is not authority. It is the circle. No throne in the middle. People sitting around a shared space. Different opinions, different interests, different experiences, yet one problem placed before everyone. That image feels surprisingly modern, reminding us that the future of governance may depend on something very old: people willing to sit together, listen, and solve problems collectively.